

Qualitative Interview: Semi-Structured and Expert Interviews

Advanced Topics: Methodology, Philosophy, and Research Design

1. Forms of Qualitative Interviews

Semi-structured (guideline) interview: Partially standardized with open questions. Flexible order. Goal: comparability + openness.

Narrative interview (Schuetze): Only initial prompt, then active listening. Goal: biographical impromptu storytelling.

Problem-centered interview (Witzel): Focused on a social problem. Guideline + narrative elements.

Expert interview: Interviewee as representative of an institution/profession. Focus on process and interpretive knowledge.

2. Interview Guide Construction

Structure thematic area (research question) into main and sub-topics.

Per topic: 1-3 open questions (NO yes/no questions).

Question types: opening, steering, sustaining, confrontational.

Funnel principle: Start broad, become specific.

Avoid: suggestive questions, double questions, jargon, why questions.

Pretest: test guide with 2-3 persons and revise.

3. Transcription

Dresing/Pehl (2018) rules (standard in German-speaking countries):

- Verbatim transcription, not summarized.
- Dialect approximated to standard language.
- Pauses: (.) short, (..) medium, (...) long.
- Emphasis: UNDERLINED.
- Non-verbal: (laughs), (sighs).